English / Secondary

Explain a quotation in a paragraph

An analytical paragraph makes an idea clear and uses a brief piece of evidence to support it.

Core ideas

1. Start with a point that answers the question.
2. Select a short quotation and explain which detail matters.
3. Connect the language or action to an interpretation. Finish by linking back to the question.

Worked example

Practice sentence: "Mina held the unopened letter." A paragraph could argue that Mina feels hesitant. The word "unopened" suggests she has delayed confronting the message. The interpretation should be supported by the surrounding passage.

Try it yourself

1. What should the first sentence establish?
2. Why select a short quotation?
3. Is one interpretation automatically certain?

Check your answers

1. A point relevant to the question.
2. It helps focus the explanation on a relevant detail.
3. No. Check it against the wider passage and consider other supported readings.